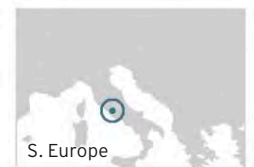




The Pantheon

The most perfectly preserved monument of ancient Rome, with the world's largest unsupported masonry dome



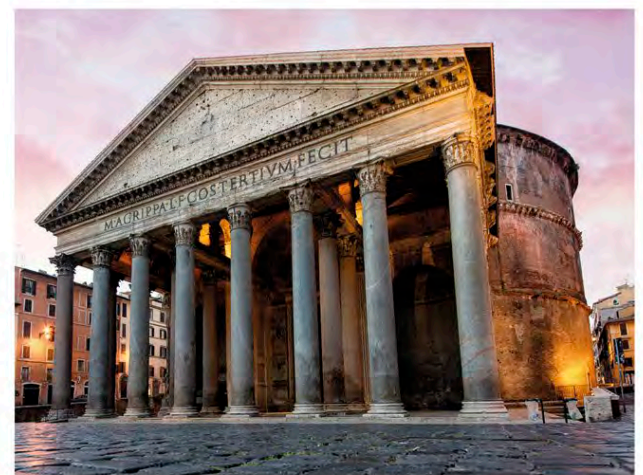
The original Pantheon, a temple to all the Roman gods, was commissioned in 27 BCE by the consul Marcus Agrippa—a great statesman and military leader, as well as a prolific builder. It was replaced by the current structure in the reign of the Emperor Hadrian some 150 years later, and, despite a number of later changes, the building completed in around 125 CE is essentially the one that still stands in central Rome today. Since 608, it has officially been a Catholic church.

Concrete construction

The design of the Pantheon is unlike that of any other ancient Roman building. Visitors pass through a massive portico with 16 granite columns and colossal bronze doors to enter an awe-inspiring

circular space under a coffered dome. The internal light comes from the oculus, a hole at the apex of the dome that also admits rain in wet weather.

Made of concrete and spanning 143 ft (43.3 m), with no supporting framework, the dome is an extraordinary feat of engineering. Although no one knows exactly how it was built, one of its secrets is that the material becomes thinner and lighter toward the top—a technique that makes the dome on the outside of the building much flatter than on the inside. The weight of the dome is supported by brick-faced concrete walls 20 ft (6 m) thick. The circular interior is richly decorated with marble and includes the tombs of the artist Raphael and of two Italian monarchs.



△ POWERFUL PORTICO

The Pantheon's impressive columned portico blocks the view of the dome from outside the building. Each column is 41 ft (12.5 m) high and 15 ft (4.5 m) in circumference.